

POU33201 — Response papers

10% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

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Mechanics settled by Noah 2026-09-16 (DECISIONS #5–8, #16): two papers, choice of week, graded, Wednesday 23:59, separate Turnitin items, no 80-cap. The worked-example placeholder below is still open.

What they are

A response paper is a short piece of **thinking**, not summary: take the week’s required readings and *do something* with them — challenge an argument, apply it to a case the author didn’t use, put two readings into conflict, or connect the reading to something happening right now. They’re also practice for the exam, which rewards the same kind of thinking.

Length: 400–500 words, 10% either way. Concision is part of the exercise.

The test: could someone who has done the reading learn something from your response? Restating the argument fails that test; arguing with it passes.

What a good one looks like

- Leads with **your claim**, not the author’s.
- Uses the reading **precisely** — one concept or finding, named.
- Brings **a case or comparison** the reading didn’t use.
- Ends with a genuine **question for the room**.

Worked example needed: one short model response (half a page) to a Week 1 or 2 reading — kills most “is this what you want?” emails. Fastest route: adapt an old MSc POP88264 prompt and write it yourself in ~20 minutes.

Mechanics

How many	Two across the term: one in teaching weeks 1–6, one in teaching weeks 8–12
Which weeks	Your choice, within each half of the term
Deadline	Wednesday 23:59 in the week you choose, via the Turnitin item for that week on Blackboard
Marking	Each paper receives a mark against the “test” above; the two together make up the 10%
Weight	10% of the module mark

The Assignment Submission Form must be page 1 of each response paper, as for all written work (see the [module outline](#)).

Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	This is the expected answer.
Brainstorming	Not permitted. The point of the exercise is that <i>you</i> had a reaction to the reading.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted for one thing only: clarifying a term or passage you could not follow after genuinely trying. Not for summarising the reading — asking a model what an article says instead of reading it defeats the entire component.
Writing assistance	Not permitted. These are short and written to prove you did the reading and thought about it. Spellcheck is fine.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted.

Optional idea (steal from NYU/Rozenas, see `_syllabus_research/SUMMARY.md` §5): let ONE of the two responses be to a piece of “dictator lit” (a chapter of *The Feast of the Goat*, Havel’s greengrocer, a Wedeen excerpt) instead of a required reading. Flagging, not deciding.